

# Safeguarding Policy

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## 1. Statement of Commitment

I recognise that safeguarding includes protecting children, young people and vulnerable adults from physical abuse, emotional abuse, sexual abuse, neglect, exploitation, domestic abuse, online harm, self-harm, radicalisation and any other form of significant harm.

I am committed to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children, young people and vulnerable adults in accordance with:

- The Code of Conduct, Performance and Ethics of the Association for Solution Focused Hypnotherapy (AfSFH)
- UK safeguarding legislation and guidance including Working Together to Safeguard Children (2023)
- The Data Protection Act 2018
- UK General Data Protection Regulation (UK GDPR) and the Data Protection Act 2018

In line with AfSFH Standard CC-S1, I will always act in the best interests of my clients and take all reasonable steps to protect them from harm

Safeguarding is everyone's responsibility. I recognise my duty to:

- Identify signs of abuse, neglect or exploitation
- Maintain appropriate professional boundaries
- Keep accurate, secure and factual records
- Act promptly where concerns arise
- Put client safety before professional loyalties
- Recognise and respond appropriately to concerns relating to domestic abuse, online safety, exploitation, self-harm and mental health difficulties.

## 2. Definitions

### Child

In accordance with *Working Together to Safeguard Children (2018)*, a child is anyone who has not yet reached their 18th birthday.

### Adult at Risk

An adult at risk is a person aged 18 years or over who has needs for care and support, is experiencing or is at risk of abuse or neglect, and is unable to protect themselves because of those care and support needs.

## **Mental Capacity**

Where concerns arise regarding an adult's ability to understand, retain, weigh or communicate information relevant to consent, consideration will be given to the principles of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.

## **3. Professional Standards and Responsibilities**

In accordance with AfSFH standards I will:

- Hold and maintain an Enhanced DBS certificate in accordance with professional, safeguarding and insurance requirements.
- Act within the limits of my competence (CC-S2)
- Maintain appropriate professional insurance
- Undertake a minimum of required CPD (15 hours annually) and supervision (minimum 6 hours annually)
- Maintain high standards of professional and personal conduct
- Monitor my own health and wellbeing to ensure safe practice
- Refer clients appropriately where needs fall outside my scope of practice
- Promote equality, dignity and respect, regardless of sex, gender identity, age, culture, sexual orientation, religion, socio-economic status or lifestyle

Professional boundaries will be maintained at all times. Relationships with clients remain professional in nature.

## **4. Informed Consent**

In line with AfSFH Standard 5.1

- Fully informed signed consent will be obtained prior to therapy
- Clients will be informed of:
  - The nature of Solution Focused Hypnotherapy
  - Financial arrangements
  - Their right to ask questions
  - Their right to discontinue therapy at any time

### **Children**

- Written consent will be obtained from a person with parental responsibility (in line with the Children Act 1989).
- The child or young person will receive an age-appropriate explanation of the process.
- Therapy will only proceed where the young person is willing to engage voluntarily.

- I will identify where another appropriate adult should be present (particularly under 16), in line with AfSFH and insurance requirements

### **Vulnerable Adults**

Where capacity to consent may be affected by learning difficulty, disability, cognitive impairment or language barriers, steps will be taken to ensure consent is fully informed and understood.

I will also comply with any additional consent requirements stipulated by my insurer.

## **5. Confidentiality and Data Protection**

In accordance with AfSFH Standard 5.3

- All client information will remain confidential.
- Information will only be used for the purpose for which it was given.
- Records (paper or electronic) will be securely stored and protected against loss, damage or unauthorised access.
- Clients will be informed of their rights regarding access, rectification and deletion of data.

### **Disclosure of Information**

Disclosure may occur:

- With client consent
- Where legally required
- Where I believe there is a risk of serious harm to the client or others

I am aware of the safeguarding provisions within the Data Protection Act 2018, particularly the section relating to safeguarding children and individuals at risk. This clarifies when information may be shared with or without consent in order to protect an individual from significant harm.

If information is shared without consent, it will be:

- Necessary
- Proportionate
- Lawful
- Clearly recorded

In the event of a data breach, I will follow ICO guidance and AfSFH requirements, including notifying my Supervisor and the client where appropriate

## **6. Record Keeping**

In line with AfSFH Standard 2.4

Records will include:

- Signed consent forms (parental where under 18)
- Initial Consultation information
- Session progress notes
- Relevant correspondence

All notes will be:

- Accurate
- Objective
- Factual
- Free from judgemental or emotive language
- Attributable to me as the practitioner

Records may be shared appropriately in safeguarding situations.

## **7. Online Safeguarding**

In addition to AfSFH guidance for conducting therapy online

### **Pre-Consultation**

- An online meeting or phone call will take place with the parent/responsible adult before working with a child.
- Agreement will be reached regarding who may be present.
- Visual identification of any additional attendee will be obtained.

### **Booking and Communication**

- Sessions will be arranged through the parent/responsible adult.
- Links will be sent to the responsible adult.
- Clear session details will be provided.

### **Safe Online Environment**

Expectations include:

- Use of a suitable private space
- Appropriate dress and language
- Phones switched off unless required for connection backup
- Option to blur backgrounds
- Reminder of safeguarding expectations at the start of sessions

Please note: online sessions will not be recorded unless explicitly agreed in advance by all relevant parties and appropriate consent has been obtained.

## 8. Responding to Safeguarding Concerns

In accordance with AfSFH Standard 5.2

If I suspect that a child or vulnerable adult:

- Has suffered significant harm
- Is at risk of significant harm
- Poses a serious risk to themselves or others

I will:

1. Record the concern factually and promptly.
2. Follow local safeguarding procedures.
3. Make a referral immediately.
4. Inform my AfSFH Supervisor for guidance and support.
5. Place client safety above professional loyalties (CC-S1.4)

## 9. Concerns About Other Practitioners

In line with AfSFH Standards CC-S1 and CC-S4

If I suspect inappropriate conduct by another practitioner:

- I will document factual information.
- I will assess the seriousness of the concern.
- If the individual is an AfSFH member, I will contact the Head of Professional Standards.
- If registered with another regulatory body, I will report concerns to that organisation.
- Where appropriate, I will follow local safeguarding procedures.

The welfare of vulnerable individuals will always take precedence over professional relationships.

## 10. Local Safeguarding Contacts

### North Somerset – Children's Social Care

If a child is at risk of significant harm:

North Somerset Children's Social Care

Tel: 01275 888 808

Out of hours: 01454 615 165

Website:

<http://www.n-somerset.gov.uk/my-services/children-young-people-families/safeguarding-at-risk-children/child-protection>

If a child is in immediate danger, I will contact emergency services (999).

### **North Somerset Safeguarding Adults Team**

Telephone: 01275 888 801

Website: [www.n-somerset.gov.uk](http://www.n-somerset.gov.uk)

If an adult is at immediate risk of harm, emergency services (999) will be contacted.

### **Policy Review**

This policy will be reviewed annually or sooner if:

- AfSFH guidance changes
- Legislation changes
- Local safeguarding procedures change
- Significant safeguarding incidents occur within practice

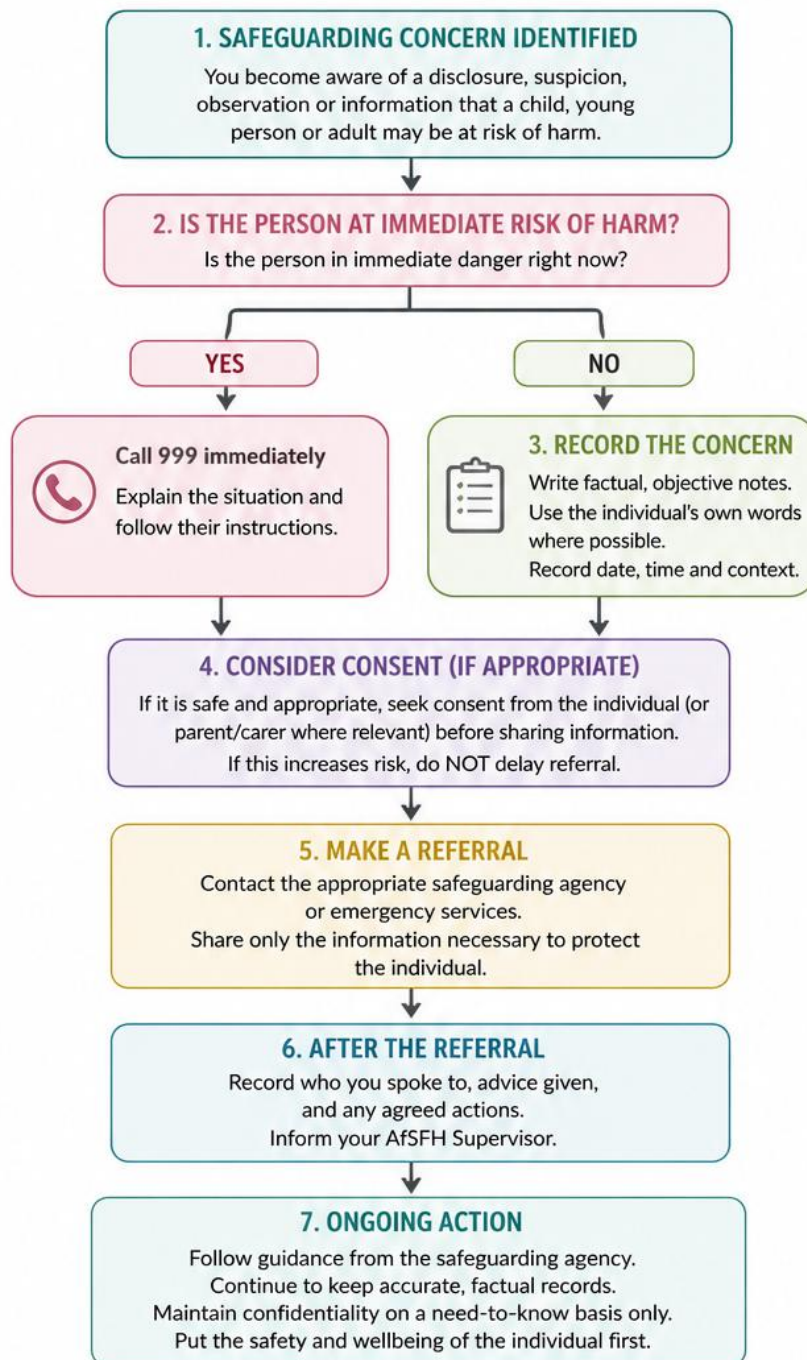
Policy Version: 2.0

Last Reviewed: June 2026

Next Review Date: June 2027

# SAFEGUARDING REFERRAL FLOWCHART

## Children, Young People and Adults at Risk



### IMPORTANT REMINDERS



Your duty is to safeguard and protect, not to investigate.



Share information only with those who need to know.



Keep all information secure and confidential in line with GDPR and safeguarding legislation.



If you are unsure, always seek advice from the safeguarding agency.

### WHO TO CONTACT

#### CHILDREN AND YOUNG PEOPLE

North Somerset Children's Social Care

☎ 01275 888 808

🌐 [www.n-somerset.gov.uk](http://www.n-somerset.gov.uk)

**If a child is at immediate risk of harm, call 999.**

#### ADULTS AT RISK

North Somerset Safeguarding Adults Team

☎ 01275 888 801

🌐 [www.n-somerset.gov.uk](http://www.n-somerset.gov.uk)

**If an adult is at immediate risk of harm, call 999.**

#### OUT OF HOURS (CHILDREN AND ADULTS)

Emergency Duty Team

☎ 01278 646 777

**If at immediate risk of harm, always call 999.**



**Remember:** If you believe a child, young person or adult is at immediate risk of harm, do not wait. **Call 999** first, then inform the appropriate safeguarding agency.